

01

THE THREE POSITIONS □

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Exclusivism: only one religion is true; salvation is found only within it; other faiths are false. □ The lapidary Latin tag is *extra ecclesiam nulla salus* ("outside the Church there is no salvation"). □□ Attribution discipline: the doctrine is standardly traced to Cyprian of Carthage (d.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Inclusivism: one's own religion is the fullest truth, but other religions contain partial truth and their adherents may be saved through it (Karl Rahner's "anonymous Christians").

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

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UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

258), whose own wording in Epistle 73 is *salus extra ecclesiam non est* — "there is no salvation outside the Church"; he also writes that one cannot have God as Father who does not have the Church as mother (De Ecclesiae Catholicae Unitate 6).

ANSWER LINE: ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM (Recommended opening definition): Exclusivism reserves decisive truth or salvation for one tradition, inclusivism admits truth elsewhere under one fulfilment, and pluralism treats multiple traditions as independently valid responses to ultimate reality.

02

THE VEDANTIC / INDIAN MODEL (2025 PYQ) □

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

"Ekam sad viprā bahudhā vadanti" — Rgveda 1.164.46, from the *asya vāmasya* riddle-hymn ascribed to Dirghatamas — "the one existent, the wise speak of in many ways". □□ Attribution discipline (examiner-visible): (i) cite the reference as RV 1.164.46, not vaguely as "the Vedas"; (ii) the verse's own context is the naming of deities — it lists Indra, Mitra, Varuṇa, Agni, the celestial Garutmān, Yama and Mātariśvan as names of "the one existent" — so its native subject is the unity of the Vedic pantheon, not the unity of the world's religions; (iii) its extension into a charter of inter-religious pluralism is a nineteenth- and twentieth-century development (Vivekananda, Radhakrishnan, Gandhi) and must be argued for, not asserted by citation; (iv) common transliteration variants (*ekam sat vipra bahudhā vadanti*) are acceptable, but keep one form consistently. □ Used with that discipline it remains the strongest single Indian text for the pluralist case — precisely because it distinguishes one referent from many names. □

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Vivekananda — Universal Religion: all religions are true, different paths to the same goal (the one Reality); they are stages/varieties suited to different temperaments — "as many faiths, so many paths." No religion should destroy another; harmony & acceptance (not mere tolerance). □

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Vedāntic pluralism distinguishes one ultimate reality from diverse conceptual and devotional approaches, but unity must not erase genuine doctrinal contradiction.

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03

THE PROBLEM OF ABSOLUTE TRUTH (2022, 2024 PYQ) □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

But one can hold that there is an Absolute Truth (the Real/Brahman) while recognising all religions as partial, perspectival approaches to it → an absolute referent with pluralist access.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The worry (2022): "unquestionable acceptance of only one Absolute Truth will inevitably result in religious exclusivism" → and exclusivism breeds conflict/intolerance. □

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

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UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Commitment to absolute truth does not entail epistemic absolutism: reality may be determinate even when finite religious formulations remain partial and corrigible.

ANSWER LINE: Commitment to absolute truth does not entail epistemic absolutism: reality may be determinate even when finite religious formulations remain partial and corrigible.

04

COMPARISON GRID □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

□ The high-scoring line: belief in an Absolute (Real/Brahman) is compatible with pluralism if truth-claims are held as partial & perspectival (Anekāntavāda/Hick) — this defuses the "absolute truth → exclusivism → conflict" chain.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

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UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: □ The high-scoring line: belief in an Absolute (Real/Brahman) is compatible with pluralism if truth-claims are held as partial & perspectival (Anekāntavāda/Hick) — this defuses the "absolute truth → exclusivism → conflict" chain.

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05

FOUNDATIONAL STATEMENT BANK □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

1. □ Ekam sat viprā bahudhā vadanti is conventionally rendered as one reality spoken of under many names; its modern pluralist use requires argument beyond citation.

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

3. □ Hick's pluralist hypothesis relocates the centre from one religion to the transcategorical Real.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

2. □ Vivekananda presents religions as diverse paths appropriate to different dispositions and calls for acceptance rather than mere tolerance.

ANSWER LINE: 1. □ Ekam sat viprā bahudhā vadanti is conventionally rendered as one reality spoken of under many names; its modern pluralist use requires argument beyond citation.

06

APPLIED-QUESTION DRILLS □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

10. [Truth is one] "'Truth is one, yet people perceive differently' — evaluate in the Indian context." (2018, 15m) → §2 + RV 1.164.46 discipline + anekāntavāda.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

2. [Absolute truth] "'One Absolute Truth → religious exclusivism.' Discuss." (2022) → §3.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

3. [Pluralism-conflict] "Does pluralism invite inter-religious conflict & destroy religion's truth?" (2023) → §3.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: 1. [Vedantic] "Vedantic religious pluralism & Vivekananda's Universal Religion vs conflicting truth-claims." (2025, 20m) → §2.

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07

PARITY BENCH — Indian and Western resources for the same four problems □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Pluralism must answer four distinct questions—truth, salvation, coexistence and epistemic humility—rather than treating social tolerance as proof that all doctrines are true.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

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